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tech

REVIEWS

Google Pixel 6a

For the hardcore Android purists

It's been a hot minute since Google brought one of its beloved Pixel phones to Indian shores. We're glad the Pixel 6a has arrived, but boy has it arrived to rife competition. So, will the Pixel 6a make a solid mark in the high-end smartphone segment in India or will it fade back from users' peripheral vision? Let's find that out and more.

BUILD AND DESIGN

The Pixel 6a carries over the same design language as the Pixel 6 and Pixel 6 Pro.. The black camera bar on the back of the phone breaks up the coloured area of the Pixel 6a's rear panel, providing a pretty clean look overall. The back finish, however, is a notorious fingerprint and smudge magnet. The camera bar protrudes from the frame slightly.

It carries an IP67 dust and water resistance rating. The front has a small punch hole cutout for the selfie camera and fairly thick bezels with a thicker chin bezel and comes with an in-display optical fingerprint scanner.

DISPLAY

As for the display, the phone sports a 6.1-inch OLED panel with Full HD+ resolution. You also get HDR support and a High Brightness Mode on the device. The display has a fairly commonplace 20:9 aspect ratio with support for 24-bit colour. It provides true blacks, vivid colours, excellent viewing angles, and good sunlight legibility. We recorded a maximum brightness of 502 nits, which is pretty decent and the display is capable of going higher on High Brightness Mode. The refresh rate is where the display stumbles in comparison to the competition. The Pixel 6a supports only 60 Hz refresh rate, which seems downright comical for a phone at this price.

PERFORMANCE

The Pixel 6a houses Google's in-house



developed Tensor chipset paired with 128 GB UFS 3.1 storage and 6 GB LPDDR5 RAM. The phone performs well as a daily driver with barely any hitches. The phone did heat up considerably when clicking photos, shooting videos and updating apps (touching 45 degrees Celsius). This caused some minor lags and stutters. Google's Titan M2 security chip shows that atleast they doing the work to ensure user security and privacy.

CAMERA

The device houses two rear camera sensors - a 12.2 MP primary sensor - which has been tried and tested since the Pixel 2 days - and a 12 MP ultrawide shooter. But honestly, there's not much to complain about even with the older sensor we have got here. Photos in daylight look fantastic, with crisp details and realistic colours. Primarily because of Google's tuning and exceptional computational photography. In low light, Google's exceptional Night Mode worked wonders - clicking photos that you could barely tell apart from well-lit ones. The 8 MP selfie camera

also clicks some good pictures with true-to-life colours and decent detail, but they appear softer than the primary sensor. Add to this stellar performance Google's editing features such as Face Unblur, Magic Eraser and more, and you get a reliable and well-rounded performance matched by almost no phone at this price.

BATTERY

Some global Pixel 6 and 6 Pro reviews have complained about mediocre battery life. Thankfully, this didn't translate to the Pixel 6a in our experience. The phone routinely lasted a day with ease with normal usage. We got a screen-on time of about 5 hours which is pretty good for a 4,410 mAh battery. The 18 W fast charging speeds though are nothing to write home about. The phone took 1 hour and 49 minutes

to go from zero to full. Also, there's no wireless charging on the phone. The company also hasn't packaged a charging adapter in the box.

VERDICT

The Google Pixel 6a provides nothing short of stellar performance in two areas - software

and camera. For the price, this is pretty much the best software and camera experience you can get. This phone isn't meant for a power user or a feature seeker - it is meant for those who truly enjoy the Pixel experience and want a set of reliable shooters for every occasion. And for those individuals, it is truly a Pixel Perfect smartphone.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

PROCESSOR: Google Tensor (5 nm) | GPU: Mali-G78 MP20 | INTERNAL STORAGE: 128 GB | RAM: 6 GB | DISPLAY: 6.1-inches OLED display, Full HD+ resolution, HDR certified | DISPLAY REFRESH RATE: 60 Hz | OS: Android 12 | CAMERAS (REAR): 12.2 MP primary, 12 MP ultrawide | CAMERA (FRONT): 8 MP | VIDEO: Up to 4K @ 60 fps | BATTERY: 4,410 mAh | CHARGING: 18 W fast charging USB PD 3.0 | COLOURS: Chalk, Charcoal | WEIGHT: 178 g

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